The Ch(e)at Code

Agent Patterns for Copilot Chat

B A START

ISSUE #014 • JUNE 30, 2026 • 🧠 CONCEPTUAL PATTERN

Every agent your customer has built waits for someone to open a chat window and type a question. The project health bot sits idle until a PM remembers to ask. The compliance checker gathers dust until audit season. The knowledge agent has perfect answers — but nobody thinks to ask. Your customers have invested in AI tools that only work when humans remember to use them.

This issue's pattern: Proactive Agent Triggers — a design framework that inverts the agent interaction model from "user asks, agent answers" to "agent watches, agent alerts." The most valuable agent behavior isn't responding faster. It's reaching out before anyone thinks to ask.

🧩 PATTERN BREAKDOWN

Proactive Agent Triggers

Scheduled scans + event-driven triggers + threshold monitoring + severity-based routing

The value inversion: Reactive agents save time when users ask. Proactive agents save time because users *don't have to ask*. This is a 10x difference. Catching a missed deadline before it's missed, flagging a budget overrun before month-end, surfacing a compliance gap before the auditor finds it — these are the moments that turn an "AI experiment" into an indispensable team member. The most valuable thing an agent can do is make itself impossible to ignore.

Key insight: Proactive agents are the strongest expansion play. The customer already has a reactive agent. This pattern turns it into an always-on assistant that delivers value even when no one is in the chat window. It's the difference between a search bar and a co-worker.

The pattern has four design decisions:

1. **Choose your trigger type.** Not all proactive behaviors are created equal. Each trigger type serves a different use case:

THREE TRIGGER TYPES

🕘 **Scheduled** — runs on a cadence
Daily standup summary, weekly health check, monthly compliance scan

⚡ **Event-Driven** — fires when data changes
New document uploaded, status field changed, approval completed
(See Issue #006: Meeting-to-Knowledge Pipeline for a working example)

📈 **Threshold** — activates when a metric crosses a boundary
Spend > 80% of budget, overdue items > 5, SLA response > 24 hours

2. **Solve the notification problem before you build.** This is where most proactive agent projects fail. Too many alerts and users develop notification fatigue — they ignore everything. Too few alerts and users don't see value — the agent gets turned off. The design principle: *severity-based routing, user-controlled frequency, and snooze/dismiss capability*. Every proactive alert must have an escape hatch. If users can't control the volume, they'll kill the channel.

3. **Match the channel to the urgency.** Not every alert deserves a Teams ping. Route by severity:

CHANNEL STRATEGY

🚨 **Push** (Teams message) — high urgency, needs immediate attention

📧 **Digest** (email summary) — informational, weekly cadence

💡 **Ambient** (Viva Insights card) — awareness, no action required

💬 **Conversational** (next chat) — low priority, surfaced when user engages

4. **Build the feedback loop from Day 1.** Track what users snooze, dismiss, and act on. If a user dismisses five "info" alerts in a row, reduce info alert frequency automatically. If they always act on "warning" items within an

hour, consider promoting those to "push" channel. The proactive agent that learns user preferences is the one that survives past the pilot.

⚠ **Design warning:** The biggest failure mode isn't building the wrong triggers — it's building too many. Start with exactly one trigger type (scheduled is the easiest). Prove that users engage with the alerts before adding event-driven or threshold triggers. A proactive agent that sends one useful alert per day beats one that sends ten alerts nobody reads.

🏆 WHERE THIS PATTERN LANDS

- **Project management & PMOs** — weekly health checks that surface overdue items, at-risk milestones, and resource conflicts before the Monday standup
- **Compliance & audit** — threshold triggers on certificate expirations, policy violations, and regulatory deadlines that fire before the audit team arrives
- **Finance & procurement** — budget burn rate alerts when spend crosses 80%, 90%, and 95% thresholds with escalating urgency
- **IT operations & support** — SLA breach warnings when ticket response times approach the threshold, sent to the on-call engineer via Teams
- **Any organization** where the most expensive failures are the ones nobody noticed until it was too late

Positioning tip: Frame this as the difference between a search bar and a co-worker. A search bar waits for you to ask. A co-worker taps you on the shoulder and says "hey, you should look at this." Proactive agents are the shoulder tap. Customers who already have reactive agents are the perfect audience — this is their natural next step.

⚡ QUICK TIPS

✓ **Scheduled triggers are the on-ramp.** Event-driven and threshold triggers require connector setup and monitoring infrastructure. A scheduled Power Automate flow that runs daily at 8 AM requires nothing but a recurrence trigger and a data query. Start there. Always.

✓ **Issue #006's Meeting-to-Knowledge Pipeline is already event-driven.** If your customer built that pipeline, they already have the pattern —

a new transcript triggers enrichment and indexing. Point this out as proof of concept: "You've already built a proactive trigger. Let's apply the same model to deadlines, budgets, and compliance."

✓ **Adaptive Cards are the delivery mechanism.** Don't send plain text Teams messages. Adaptive Cards give you action buttons (Open, Snooze, Dismiss), severity badges, and structured layouts. They're the difference between an alert users glance at and one they act on.

✓ **Next issue (#015) builds this pattern end-to-end.** We'll walk through Copilot Studio + Power Automate + Teams Adaptive Cards + Dataverse to build a working proactive agent. If you want to get ahead, pick one SharePoint list with a due date column — you'll need it.

Got an agent or pattern to share?

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